his war debts, with no further objections from the papacy. In 1306, he exiled all of the Jews from France so that he could confiscate their property. The following year, he made a move against the Knights Templar, the richest military order in Europe.

Until now, the Templars had been answerable only to the pope. But Clement V, Philip's lapdog, quickly agreed to remove his protection. As soon as he did so, Philip issued a letter ordering the arrest of the Templars throughout France, on charges that the Templars indulged in all sorts of secret and occultish acts of demon worship. They were to be treated as heretics: "You will hold them captive to appear before an ecclesiastical court," he wrote, to the chief inquisitor of Paris; "you will seize their movable and immovable goods and hold the seizures under strict supervision in our name."[10]

This included a vast amount of treasure, held in the Templar fortress right outside the walls of Paris. The inquisitor duly sent out his agents, and all through France the Templars were suddenly arrested and imprisoned. Among them was Jacques de Molay, the sixty-year-old Grand Master of the order. Imprisoned, starved, and threatened with torture, de Molay confessed that, yes, when he had joined the Templars forty-two years earlier, he had been required to spit on a cross and deny the divinity of Christ; which he had done, but "not with his heart."[11]



59.1 The Papal Palace at Avignon.